GLASSHOUSE

CULTIVATED IMAGE



What better than the sight of your leader displaying he is not afraid to get his hands dirty? So, when Rahul Gandhi on July 8 made an unscheduled stop in Haryana, en route to Shimla from Delhi, rolled up his trousers and joined farmers in planting paddy seedlings, and even drove a tractor, camera-happy Congressmen got busy. As the video went viral, the BJP was the first to point out that Rahul was playing farmer with a mic on his shirt. Soon, the behind-the-scenes video of the Rahul clip was leaked and BJP social media handles went berserk alleging farmers were pushed and shoved during the "staged interaction". Now, it seems, cellphones and other digital equipment, except by designated camerapersons, have been banned while such 'impromptu' videos of Rahul are being shot.

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

NOT OUR CONGRESS



Y.S. Sharmila, 49, the younger sister of Andhra Pradesh chief minister Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy, is bracing to disband her YSR Telangana Party and join the Congress. The YSR family broke away from the Grand Old Party after it had rejected Jagan's claims to succeed their father Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy, who had died in a tragic helicopter crash in September 2009, as chief minister of erstwhile Andhra Pradesh. But the homecoming may not be easy. While her mother is opposed to the plan, Telangana Congress chief A. Revanth Reddy and other party leaders are wary of her emerging as a power centre. Their advice? She should join the Congress in neighbouring Andhra Pradesh.

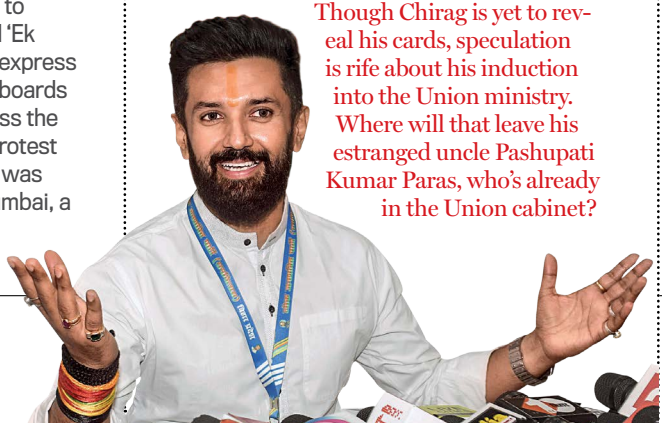


A Sign of the Times

While the shift in political loyalties and alignments in Maharashtra is enough to put a seasoned somersault artist to shame, the **Raj Thackeray**-led Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS) has used the occasion to launch a signature campaign called 'Ek Sahi Santapachi' or 'A signature to express frustration'. As part of it, huge flex boards were put up at busy junctions across the state for citizens to register their protest with a signature. Also among them was an RSS worker in full uniform in Mumbai, a moment that has gone viral on social media.

CABINET OF CURIOSITIES

Just before Lok Janshakti Party leader **Chirag Paswan** held discussions with his partymen on July 9 about which party he should ally with, he also had a 40-minute-long closed-door meeting with Nityanand Rai, Union home minister Amit Shah's deputy, in Patna. Though Chirag is yet to reveal his cards, speculation is rife about his induction into the Union ministry. Where will that leave his estranged uncle Pashupati Kumar Paras, who's already in the Union cabinet?



ANI

The New SuperCM

Former Union finance secretary **Hasmukh Adhia** seems to have become the most sought-after government official in Gujarat these days. Appointed advisor to Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel within a fortnight of the latter assuming office in December 2022, he is credited with several of the government's key decisions in the past six months. However, it was his appointment last month as chairman of GIFT City and two other state PSUs that has brought him to the forefront. Adhia's heft in the power corridors is rising, rivalling that of K. Kailashnathan, the CM's chief principal secretary. Like Kailashnathan in the past, Adhia now is referred to as the 'SuperCM'.



Kaushik Deka with Jumana Shah, Amarnath K. Menon, Amitabh Srivastava and Dhaval Kulkarni